

CHAPTER ONE

**Ash on the Index Room**

Ash should not have been able to enter the Index Room.

Mara Venn knew that before she knew anything else. Before she checked the door seal, before she held her breath beneath the brass vent, before she touched one cautious finger to the grey dust gathering on the corner of Record 19-F. The room had no windows. Its lamps burned clean mineral oil. Its shelves were locked behind civic glass that had survived two riots, one flood and every inspection the Council could invent.

Still, ash lay across the record like a sentence someone had started and abandoned.

Mara did not move for several seconds. In the archive, hesitation was usually a virtue. It kept ink from spilling, pages from tearing, junior staff from speaking too quickly in front of people whose signatures could end a career. Tonight, hesitation felt less like discipline and more like fear.

She looked toward the door.

No footsteps. No voices. Only the low tick of the catalogue clock and the soft electric hum of the preservation lamps.

The record beneath the ash concerned the eastern pier of the Ash Gate. That alone was enough to make her hands cold.

Every child in Veyr knew the public version. The Ash Gate was a monument. The Gate marked the end of the last war. The Gate remained sealed because the city had triumphed, because order had held, because the Council remembered what the people must never forget.

Mara had copied those words often enough to hate their rhythm.

She reached for the linen cloth beside her station, then stopped. Cleaning the ash would destroy evidence. Reporting it would bring a Council inventory team before dawn. Ignoring it would be worse if anyone discovered she had seen it first.

Her father would have laughed at that. Quietly, because he had never been reckless in public. Then he would have asked the question that ruined people.

*What does the record need you not to notice?*

Mara leaned closer.

The ash had gathered in the groove between two pages. Not randomly. Not as dust falls. It traced a thin grey line beneath a marginal note that should not have existed in this copy.

The official hand was square, approved, anonymous.

The note beneath it was narrow and slanted left.

Mara knew that hand.

She had learned her letters from it.

